

HUNDRED YEARS' WAR



IN 1337, EDWARD III of England (r.1327–77) began a bitter war with France that was to last for over 100 years. Edward and his successors felt they had a claim to the French throne, but they also wanted to protect their inherited lands in south-western France. In the beginning, under Edward III and his great-grandson Henry V, England seemed to be winning. Then, as the independent duchy of Burgundy abandoned the English and joined forces with the French army, fortunes changed, and France began to win. In the end, the French drove the English from their country, leaving Calais as the only English possession on the European mainland.



French crossbowman

Opponents

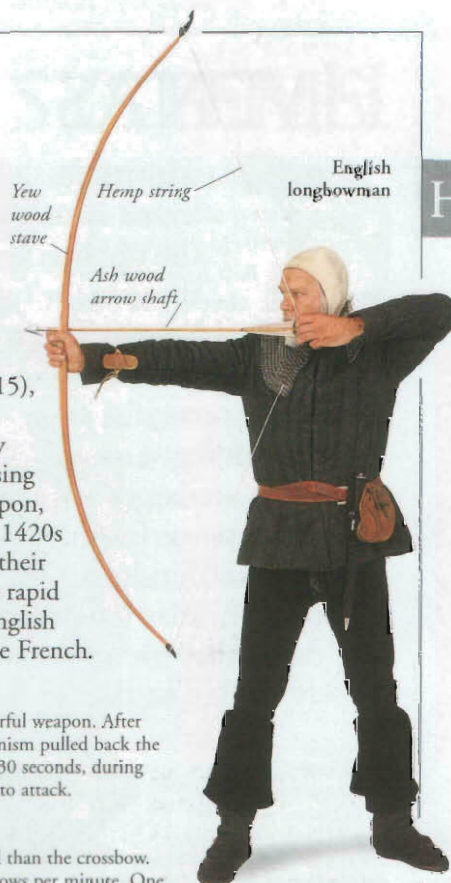
In battles such as Crécy (1346) and Agincourt (1415), the French used cavalry charges, which were easily broken by the English using their new, powerful weapon, the longbow. From the 1420s on, the French rebuilt their army and began to use rapid assaults, which broke the English army and gave victory to the French.

French crossbows

The crossbow was a slow but powerful weapon. After each shot, a lever or winder mechanism pulled back the string for the next shot. This took 30 seconds, during which time the Bowman was open to attack.

English longbows

The longbow was quicker to reload than the crossbow. An archer could shoot up to 12 arrows per minute. One arrow could pierce armour from as far away as 180 m (600 ft) – but they were not as accurate as the crossbow bolts.



English longbowman

Early phases of the war

Helped by their Burgundian allies, the English had many successes until 1429, when the French, under the brilliant leadership of Joan of Arc, defeated them at Orléans. The French-Burgundian alliance of 1435 proved too strong for England, which steadily lost its French lands.



1340–1360

The English inherited Aquitaine, and, in 1347, captured Calais. In 1359, they attempted to invade French territory. The French held them off, and the Treaty of Brétigny followed in 1360.

1360–1429

Although the English had lost Aquitaine by 1429, they had gained territory in northern France, including Normandy. Within 30 years they lost everything until, by 1453, their only possession in France was Calais.

Leaders of the war

The personalities and military skills of Joan of Arc and Henry V of England inspired their followers with courage and trust. The dukes of Burgundy were crucial for a different reason: they held the balance of power between England and France.



The Black Prince

Named because he wore black armour, Edward (1330–76) was the eldest son of Edward III. He fought at Crécy and Poitiers, and ruled Aquitaine in the 1360s.



Charles VII of France

Charles VII (r.1422–61) was not crowned King of France until 1429, after the victory at Orléans. He was then able to organize an army against the English.



Philip the Good

Philip (1396–1467), duke of Burgundy, was an English ally at first, but then changed sides and helped France to victory. He built his dukedom into one of the most powerful in Europe.

Henry V

Henry V (r.1413–1422) of England captured major cities, such as Rouen, and led his men to many victories. Through his marriage to Catherine of Valois, he would have inherited the French throne from his father-in-law, King Charles VI of France, but he died before Charles. Shakespeare's play *Henry V* describes Henry's achievements.



Joan of Arc

Joan of Arc (1412–31) heard voices telling her to free France. At 17, she led the French to victory against the English. Later, she was captured and sold to the English, who burnt her at the stake as a heretic. In 1920, she was declared a saint.



Timeline

1346 Battle of Crécy: England builds up strength in France.

1360 Peace of Brétigny: Edward III acquires Aquitaine and gives up other French claims.



1415 English victory at Agincourt; Henry V controls Normandy.

1420 Henry V named heir to French throne.

1422 Charles VI and Henry V die.

1429 Joan of Arc liberates Orléans and escorts Charles VII to Reims to be anointed as king of France.

1431 Joan of Arc is burnt at the stake as a heretic.

1435 Council of Arras: Burgundy joins forces with the French army.

1453 French victory at Castillon: England loses all her French lands, except Calais.

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